

The science of the mind



Studies of animal behaviour offered early clues to the way in which our brains solve problems such as mazes.

Psychology evolved from philosophical roots, but set out to provide a scientific basis for our understanding of the human mind and behaviour. Just as the physical sciences were beginning to answer questions that had previously been in the realm of metaphysics, so experimental psychology began to offer scientific explanations for problems of epistemology and consciousness. Where philosophers had speculated from a subjective and

often introspective standpoint, psychology based its explanations on the evidence of not only observation, but experiment. Behavioural psychologists devised tests to explore how we acquire knowledge and learn, observing not only humans but also other animals. Later, cognitive psychology examined the way our brains process information, and as the emphasis shifted from 'mind' to 'brain', psychology moved even further from philosophical speculation and became more closely associated with neuroscience. With the advent of computer technology, the analogy of electronic data processing also influenced psychological interpretations of the human brain.